

Hottest Picture on Earth

A Google Earth layer was launched by the U.K. government, that models what Earth might look like when its current temperature rises by 4 degrees

Solar voyage

A solar-powered plane designed to fly day and night has succeeded with a 24-hour voyage

Cover feature

goods. If you are resident of Mumbai, then you can also take advantage of the NGO called United Way Mumbai (<http://www.unitedwaymumbai.org>), which makes it possible for you to donate computer spares parts that are in good working condition.

Another good way of tackling e-waste envisages the manufacturer of any electronic product making arrangements for taking the device back once its lifecycle runs out. But in this case the problem is that many of the top brands in the country don't have the necessary infrastructure in place to collect their discarded products. According to a Centre for Science and Environment (CSE) report, "Most of the top brands have no take-back policy in India. So if are using a Apple, Microsoft, Panasonic, PCS, Philips, Sharp, Sony, Sony Ericsson or Toshiba device, you can't depend on the company to help you safely discard their device." Wholly Indian owned brands like Wipro and HCL have come up with very consumer friendly take-back programs. In fact, the 'Guide to Greener Electronics' initiative by Greenpeace ranks Wipro amongst the top five brands in the world as far as the take-back policy is concerned.

In an official release from Greenpeace, Abhishek Pratap, the Greenpeace India Toxics Campaigner, says, "It is

good to see Wipro making it to the top league. The recent financial meltdown has not acted as a deterrent for proactive environmental management measures at Wipro and we hope this is sustained over the long term. We expect this initiative by Wipro to catalyse other electronics brands to take similar measures" Companies like Nokia, Acer, Motorola and LG, also have collection centres in the country, but the service seems to be working only in the cities. Samsung electronics currently operates a collection point through its authorised service centre in India, but these centres will only accept discarded mobiles. According to Samsung's press release, "by the end of 2010, the company will start operating recycling programs in Delhi/NCR, Mumbai and in Bangalore."

Government initiatives

The slow pace with which our government works has certainly aggravated the problem of e-waste management in India. Finally in 2010, when lakhs of tonnes of e-waste has already vitiated the environment and damaged the health of thousands of people, the government is finally moving in the direction of enacting new laws that will make the producers of electrical and electronic equipment respon-

sible for the collection and appropriate disposal of e-waste generated at the end of life of its products. The draft of these new rules were made public on the web site of the Ministry of Environment and Forests in April this year. The proposed rules seek to place a ban on the import of used electrical and electronic equipment for charity in the country. The truth is that millions of tonnes e-waste enters the country on pretext of being reused and donated to local charities. This is because the import of e-waste is restricted.

The new set of rules will also regulate the recyclers and intermediaries, such as operators of collection centres. The end-consumer too will come under the ambit of these laws. You won't be allowed to chuck away your gizmo into the nearest garbage dump when you are done with it, you will be required by law to turn it in for recycling at a properly managed establishment. If these laws are not implemented properly, then instead of helping the country in tackling the e-waste problem, they could only have the effect of adding another layer of bureaucratic red tape to the already over-encumbered system of governance.

The Centre for Science and Environment remains unenthusiastic about the new laws that have been proposed.

According to the CSE, the proposed rules don't seem to go far enough to be effective in protecting the environment from e-waste. In its press release, the CSE says, "The proposed rules, for the first time in India, bring in the concept of extended producer responsibility, making manufacturers liable for safe disposal of electronic goods. However, they do not detail the business model for collection of e-waste from consumers. Neither do they offer any assistance to help the informal sector get organised." There is no doubt that the environment needs to be protected and nurtured, but this has to be done in a cost effective manner, otherwise the purpose behind these new laws is going to be defeated. 

INTERVIEW WITH B K SONI

Eco Recycling Limited (<http://ecoreco.com>) manages e-waste in an environmentally friendly way. The company has developed a complete spectrum of manual and technological procedures that go into e-waste management. B K Soni, the main promoter of Ecoreco, explains how his company is at the forefront of the war against e-waste.

• What is the biggest obstacle that organisations such as yours face in managing e-waste?

The main problem is that currently much of the e-waste goes to junk dealers, who sell their stuff to informal recycling centres. We are still in process of convincing individuals and corporate entities to give their e-waste to properly functioning recycling

centres such as Ecoreco.

• Where does the bulk of e-waste that you recycle come from?

Most of the material that we recycle comes from corporate entities. If a corporate entity gives us their e-waste for free, we generally use part of the value of such e-waste to donate new computer equipment to schools being run in the poorer areas.

• How do you ensure that the material gets recycled properly?

Our workers are fully trained and they take every precaution while dismantling the e-waste. The reusable material like steel, copper, aluminium, plastic, etc are separated and sent to different

industries to be recycled. While the toxic material in the e-waste is sent to government recognized facilities to be safely disposed off.

• What is your view of the e-waste laws being proposed by the government?

These laws seem too ambitious for a country like India. For instance, it is being assumed that people will call HP every time they want to get rid of an old printer, manufactured by that company. But that might not happen, many people who are not environmentally conscious will prefer to sell it to the junk dealers. What is really needed is not a new set of laws, but a change in the way people think about e-waste.

